CHAPTER 7 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

The New York City Draft Riots

For five days in July 1863, the North's largest city turned on itself — and on its Black residents. July 1863.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

For five days in July 1863, the North's largest city turned on itself — and on its Black residents. July 1863.

When a mob explodes, is there ever just one cause — or do many pressures build until something breaks?

A New Kind of Draft

MARCH 1863

By 1863, volunteering had slowed and the Union needed men. Congress passed the first federal draft — but with a loophole that enraged the poor: a drafted man could escape service by paying $300 or hiring a substitute.

Three hundred dollars was nearly a year's wages for a laborer. To working families, the message was clear and bitter: “a rich man's war and a poor man's fight.”

“The Riots at New York — the Rioters Burning and Sacking the Colored Orphan Asylum” — wood engraving, Harper's Weekly, August 1, 1863, public domain (Library of Congress).

Many Fuses, One Explosion

THE PRESSURES BUILD

Several pressures piled up at once. Many of New York's poorest workers were Irish immigrants, who competed for low-wage jobs and had been told, by some politicians, that the draft would send them to die to free enslaved people who would then take their jobs.

Add resentment of the $300 exemption, anger at the war's endless casualty lists, and deep, organized racism — and the city was a powder keg. When the draft lottery began on July 13, 1863, it exploded.

The divided nation, 1861 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

The Mob Turns on the Innocent

HARPER'S WEEKLY · AUGUST 1863

The violence quickly shifted from draft offices to the city's Black residents. Rioters burned the Colored Orphan Asylum, home to more than 200 children, who narrowly escaped out the back.

“The Riots at New York — the Rioters Burning and Sacking the Colored Orphan Asylum” — wood engraving, Harper's Weekly, August 1, 1863, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Deadliest Riot in U.S. History

FIVE DAYS OF TERROR

For five days the mob attacked draft offices, wealthy homes, and — most savagely — Black New Yorkers, lynching several and burning Black churches, homes, and the orphanage. Order was restored only when Union troops, some straight from the field at Gettysburg, marched into the city.

More than 100 people were killed, making it the deadliest riot in American history. The home front, it turned out, had its own battlefields.

"The Riots at New York — the Rioters Burning and Sacking the Colored Orphan Asylum" — wood engraving, Harper's Weekly, August 1, 1863, public domain (Library of Congress).

A NEW YORK DIARIST · JULY 1863

The lowest Irish are the scum of the earth … and the howling devils who are now disgracing the city are the worst of them. … Rabble revels.

The War's Fault Lines at Home

WHY IT MATTERS

The riots exposed the class and racial fractures running through the Union itself. The war was not just North against South; it also strained the bonds between rich and poor, native-born and immigrant, white and Black — inside the North.

Understanding the riots means seeing that big events usually have many causes at once. No single spark explains five days of fire.

"The Riots at New York — the Rioters Burning and Sacking the Colored Orphan Asylum" — wood engraving, Harper's Weekly, August 1, 1863, public domain (Library of Congress).

Untangle the Causes

YOUR TURN

You'll sort the many pressures behind the riots and practice multiple causation — the skill of explaining how several causes combine to produce one event.